HYDROXYZINE

QT prolongation
Sedating

CHEMICAL NAME (RS)-2-{2-[4-[(4-chlorophenyl)(phenyl)methyl]piperazin-1-yl]ethoxy}ethanol (hydrochloride or pamoate)
CLASS First-generation H1 antihistamine (piperazine) with anxiolytic action
TRADE NAMES Atarax · Vistaril · Ucerax

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Pruritus (urticaria, atopic dermatitis).
- Short-term management of anxiety.
- Pre-operative sedation.
- Nausea (adjunct).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** tablets or syrup.
- **IM** deep only (not IV or SC — tissue damage).

DOSAGES

- **Pruritus (adult):** 25 mg at night, increase to 25 mg 3–4 times daily.
- **Anxiety:** 50–100 mg/day in divided doses.
- Max 100 mg/day adults; 50 mg/day elderly.
- **Children:** 1–2 mg/kg/day divided (max 2 mg/kg/day).

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 15–30 min. **Duration:** 4–6 h (antipruritic up to 24 h).
- Metabolised in liver to cetirizine (active).
- Excreted in urine. **t½:** 14–20 h (longer in elderly).

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- **H1 antagonist**; subcortical depressant → anxiolytic, sedative; anticholinergic and antiemetic.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Drowsiness, dry mouth.
- Headache, dizziness.
- Fatigue.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- QT prolongation, torsades de pointes (dose-related).
- Seizures (high doses).
- Confusion in elderly; urinary retention.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Long QT, risk factors for torsades (bradycardia, hypokalaemia).
- Porphyria; early pregnancy; breastfeeding.
- Hypersensitivity to cetirizine/piperazines.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **QT-prolonging drugs** (antipsychotics, macrolides, citalopram): avoid.
- **CNS depressants:** ↑ sedation.
- **Anticholinergics:** additive.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Check ECG risk factors and electrolytes in at-risk patients.
- Assess itch, anxiety and sedation.
- Fall precautions.
- IM: deep, large muscle.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- May cause drowsiness; avoid alcohol and driving.
- Report palpitations or fainting.
- Do not exceed the prescribed dose.

KEY POINTS

- Sedating antihistamine — itch and anxiety.
- QT prolongation.
- Max 100 mg/day (50 mg elderly).
- Metabolised to cetirizine.